appointment order?" I enquired of Prof. Dhawan. "No. Don't pressurise them. Let me talk to the top-level management during my next visit to New Delhi," Prof. Dhawan said. "I know you have always had one foot in DRDO, now your whole centre of gravity seems to have shifted towards them." Perhaps what Prof. Dhawan was tel ing me had an element of truth in it, but my heart had always been at ISRO. Was he real y unaware of that?

Republic Day, 1981 brought with it a pleasant surprise. On the evening of 25 January, Mahadevan, Secretary to Prof. UR Rao, rang up from Delhi to inform me about the Home Ministry announcement about the conferment of the Padma Bhushan award on me. The next important cal was from Prof. Dhawan to congrat-ulate me. I felt blissful y elated as it was from my guru. I rejoiced with Prof. Dhawan at his receiving the Padma Vibhushan and I congratulated him wholeheartedly. I then rang up Dr Brahm Prakash and thanked him. Dr Brahm Prakash chided me for the formality and said, "I feel as if my son has got the award." I was so deeply touched by Dr Brahm Prakash's affection that I could no longer keep my emotions in check.

I fil ed my room with the music of Bismil ah Khan's